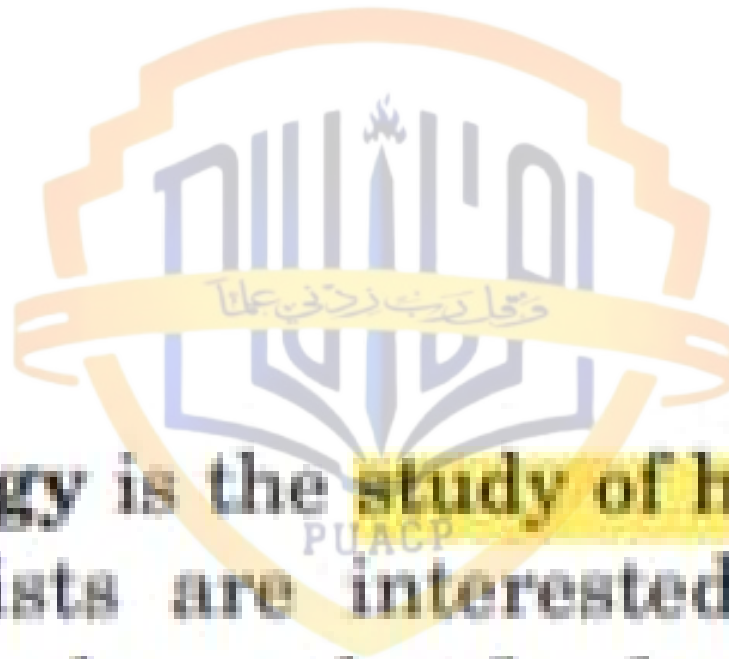




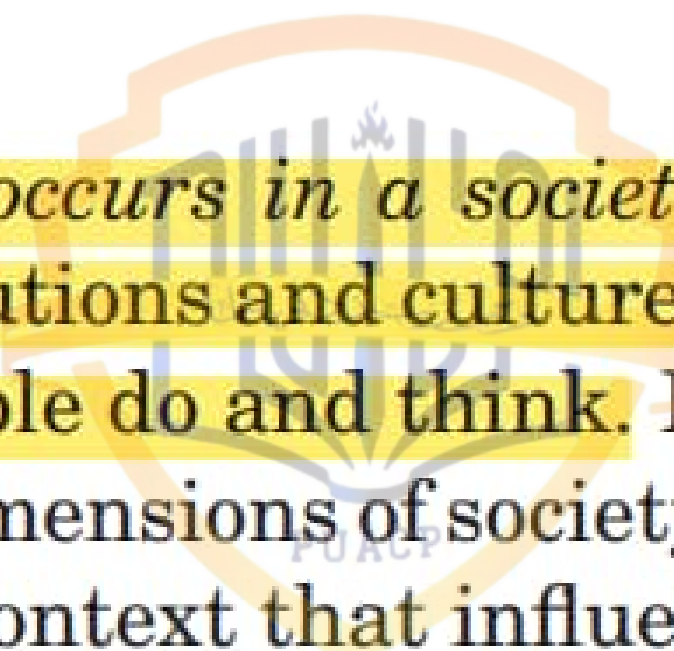
INTRODUCTION TO SOCIOLOGY

Sociology is the scientific study of human society and social interactions. As sociologists, our main goal is to understand social situations and look for repeating patterns in society. We do not use facts selectively to create a lively talk show, sell newspapers, or support one particular point of view. Instead, sociologists are engaged in a rigorous scientific endeavor, which requires objectivity and detachment.

The main focus of sociology is the group, not the individual. Sociologists attempt to understand the forces that operate throughout society—forces that mold individuals, shape their behavior, and, thus, determine social events.



Sociology is the study of human behavior in society. Sociologists are interested in the study of people and have learned a fundamental lesson: *All human*



behavior occurs in a societal context. That context—the institutions and culture that surround us—shapes what people do and think. In this book, we will examine the dimensions of society and analyze the elements of social context that influence human behavior.

Sociology is a scientific way of thinking about society and its influence on human groups. Observation, reasoning, and logical analysis are the tools of the sociologist, coupled with knowledge of

The subject matter of sociology is everywhere. This is why people sometimes wrongly believe that sociology just explains the obvious. But sociologists bring a unique perspective to understanding social behavior and social change. Even though sociologists often do research on familiar topics, such as youth cultures or relations between women and men—they do so using particular research tools and specific frames of analysis (known as sociological theory). Psychologists, anthropologists, political scientists, economists, social workers, and others also study social behavior, though each has a different perspective or “angle” on people in society. Together, these fields of study (also called disciplines) make up what are called the social sciences.

Is Sociology Common Sense?

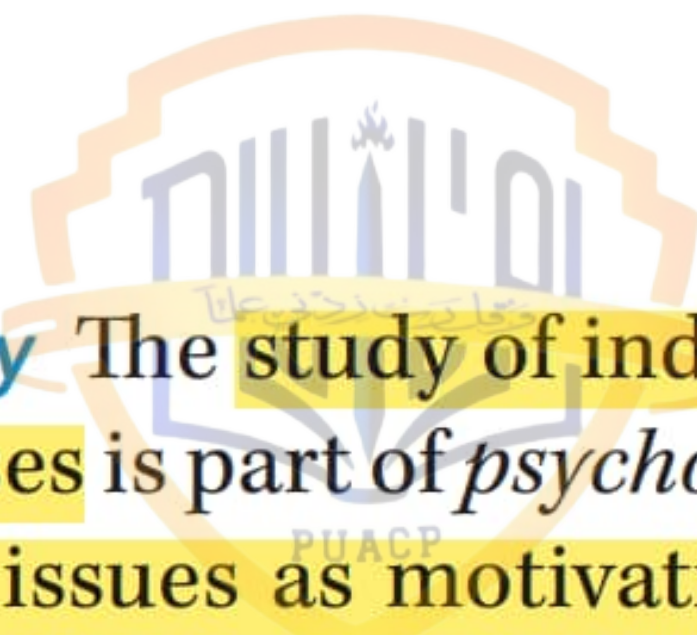
Common sense is what people develop through everyday life experiences. In a very real sense, it is the set of expectations about society and people's behavior that guides our own behavior. Unfortunately, these expectations are not always reliable or accurate because without further investigation, we tend to believe what we want to believe, to see what we want to see, and to accept as fact whatever appears to be logical. Whereas common sense is often vague, oversimplified, and often contradictory, sociology as a science attempts to be specific, to qualify its statements, and to prove its assertions.

Upon closer inspection, we find that the proverbial words of wisdom rooted in common sense are often illogical. Why, for example, should you “look before you leap” if “he who hesitates is lost”? How can “absence make the heart grow fonder” when “out of sight, out of mind”? Why should “opposites attract” when “birds of a feather flock together”? The common-sense approach to sociology is one of the dangers the new student encounters. Common sense often makes sense after the fact. It is more useful for describing events than for predicting them. It deludes us into thinking we knew the outcome all along (Hawkins and Hastie, 1990).

Sociology as a Social Science

The **social sciences** consist of *all those disciplines that apply scientific methods to the study of human behavior*. Although there is some overlap, each of the **social sciences** has its own area of investigation. It is helpful to understand each social science and examine sociology's relationship to them.

Cultural Anthropology The social science most closely related to sociology is *cultural anthropology*. The two share many theories and concepts and often overlap. The main difference is in the groups they study and the research methods they use. Sociologists tend to study groups and institutions within large, often modern, industrial societies, using research methods that enable them rather quickly to gather specific information about large numbers of people. In contrast, cultural anthropologists often immerse themselves in another society for a long period of time, trying to learn as much as possible about that society and the relationships among its people. Thus, anthropologists tend to focus on the culture of small, preindustrial societies because

The logo of the University of Al-Qadisiyah is a circular emblem. It features a central torch with a flame, set against a background of stylized Arabic calligraphy. The emblem is surrounded by a decorative border. The text 'PUACP' is visible at the bottom of the emblem.

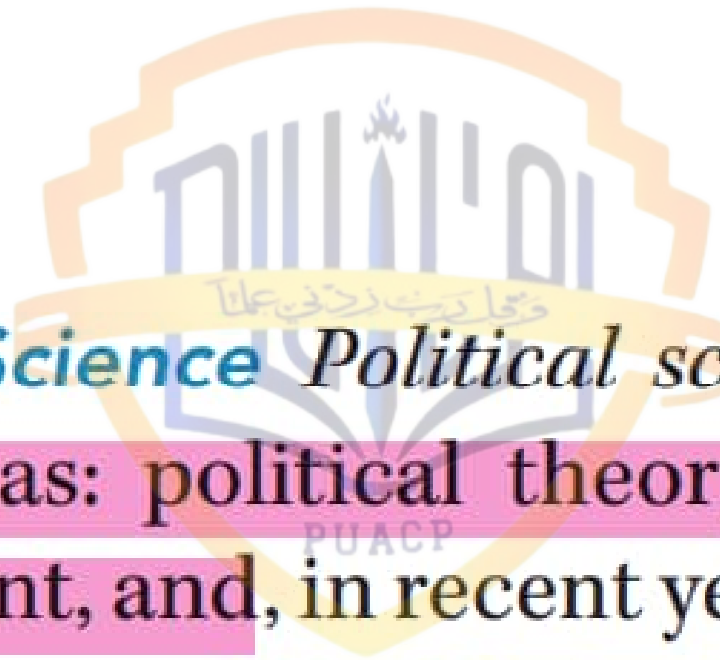
Psychology The study of individual behavior and mental processes is part of *psychology*; the field is concerned with such issues as motivation, perception, cognition, creativity, mental disorders, and personality. More than any other social science, psychology uses laboratory experiments.

Psychology and sociology overlap in a subdivision of each field known as *social psychology*—the study of how human behavior is influenced and shaped by various social situations. Social psychologists study such issues as how individuals in a group solve problems and reach a consensus or what factors might produce nonconformity in a group situation. Generally, however, psychology studies the individual, and sociology studies groups of individuals as well as society's institutions.

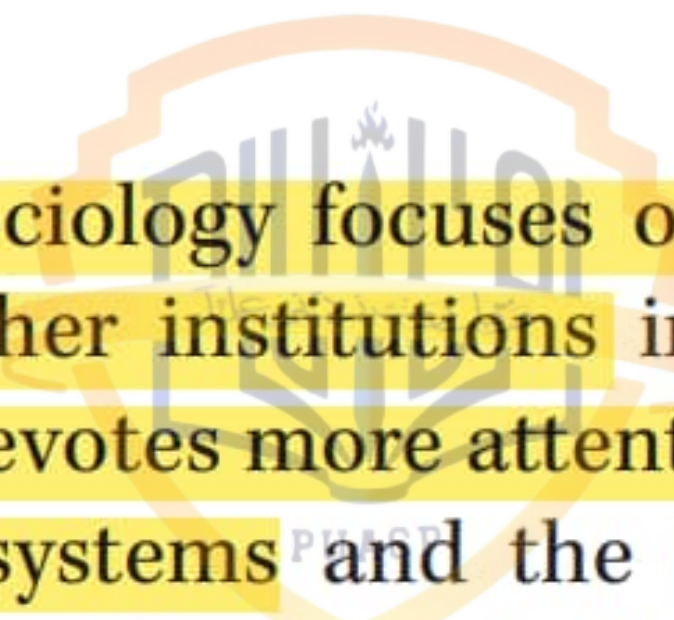
Economics Economists have developed techniques for measuring such things as prices, supply and demand, money supplies, rates of inflation, and employment. This study of the creation, distribution, and consumption of goods and services is known as *economics*. The economy, however, is just one part of society, and each individual in society decides whether to buy an American car or a Japanese import, whether she or he is able to handle the mortgage payment on a dream house, and so on. Whereas economists study price and availability factors, sociologists are interested in the social factors that influence a person's economic decisions. Does peer pressure result in buying the large flashy car, or does concern about gas mileage lead to the purchase of a fuel-efficient

History Although not exactly a social science, history shares certain attributes with sociology. The study of *history* involves looking at the past to learn what happened, when it happened, and why it happened. Sociology also looks at historical events within their social contexts to discover why things happened and, more important, to assess what their social significance was and is. Historians provide a narrative of the sequence of events during a certain period and might use sociological research methods to learn how social forces have shaped historical events. Sociologists examine historical events to see how they influenced later social situations.

Historians focus on individual events—the American



Political Science *Political science* is the study of three major areas: political theory, the actual operation of government, and, in recent years, political behavior. This emphasis on political behavior overlaps with sociology. The primary distinction between the two disciplines



is that sociology focuses on how the political system affects other institutions in society, whereas political science devotes more attention to the forces that shape political systems and the theories for understanding these forces. However, both disciplines share an interest in why people vote the way they do, why they join political movements, and how the mass media are changing political events.

The main goal of *social work* is to help people solve their problems, whereas the aim of sociology is to understand why the problems exist. Social workers provide help for individuals and families who have emotional and psychological problems or who experience difficulties that stem from poverty or other ongoing problems rooted in the structure of society. Social workers also organize community groups to tackle local issues such as housing problems and try to influence policy-making bodies and legislation. Sociologists provide many of the theories and ideas used to help others. Although sociology is not



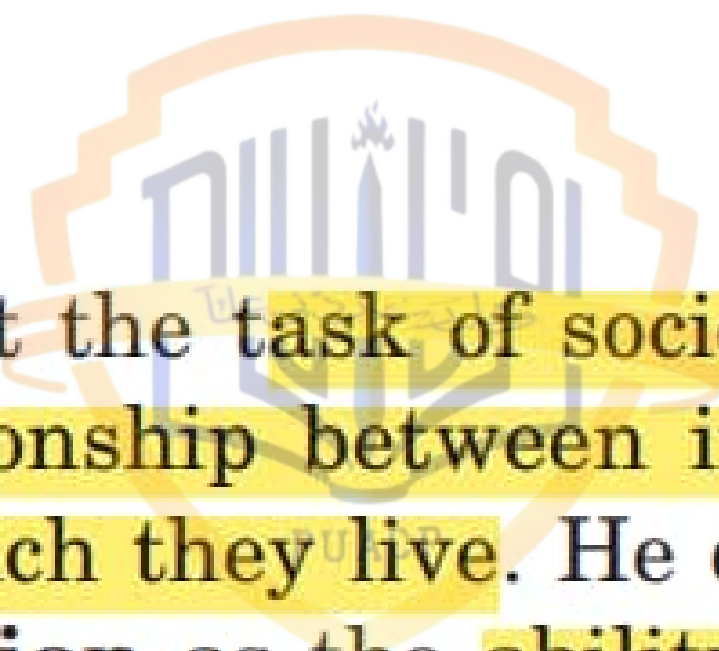
The Sociological Perspective



sociological perspective—the ability to see the societal patterns that influence individual and group life. The beginnings of the sociological perspective



C. Wright Mills (1916–1962) was one of the first to write about the sociological perspective in his classic book, *The Sociological Imagination* (1959). He



wrote that the task of sociology was to understand the relationship between individuals and the society in which they live. He defined the **sociological imagination** as the ability to see the societal patterns that influence the individual as well as groups of individuals. Sociology should be used, Mills

Sociologists are certainly concerned about individuals, but they are attuned to the social and historical context that shapes the experiences of individuals and groups. A distinction made by the sociological imagination is that between *troubles* and *issues*. **Troubles** are privately felt problems that spring from events or feelings in a person's life. **Issues** affect large numbers of people and have their origins in the institutional arrangements and history of a society (Mills 1959). This distinction is the crux of the difference between individual experience and **social structure**, defined as the organized pattern of social relationships and social institutions that together constitute society. Issues shape the context within which troubles arise. Sociologists employ the sociological perspective to understand how issues are shaped by social structures.



● THEORETICAL PERSPECTIVES

Functionalism

Functionalism—or structural functionalism, as it is often called—is rooted in the writings of Spencer and Durkheim and the work of such scholars as Parsons and Merton. **Functionalism** *views society as a system of highly interrelated structures or parts that function or operate together harmoniously.*

Functionalists analyze society by asking what each different part contributes to the smooth functioning of the whole. For example, we may assume the education system serves to teach students specific subject matter. However, functionalists might note that it acts as a system to socialize the young so that they can become members of society. The education system serves as a gatekeeper to the rewards society offers to those who follow its rules.

From the functionalist perspective, society appears quite stable and self-regulating. Much like a biological organism, society is normally in a state of equilibrium or balance. Most members of a society share a value system and know what to expect from one another.

Functionalism is a very broad theory in that it attempts to account for the complicated interrelationships of all the elements that make up human societies. In a way, it is impossible to be a sociologist and not be a functionalist because most parts of society serve some stated or unstated purpose. Functionalism is limited in one regard, however: The assumption that societies are normally in balance or harmony makes it difficult for proponents of this view to account for how social change comes about.

If major parts of society fit together smoothly, we can assume that the social system is working well. Conflict is then seen as something that disrupts the essential orderliness of the social structure and produces imbalance between the parts and the whole.

The family as an institution, for example, serves multiple functions. At its most basic level, the family has a reproductive role. Within the family, infants receive protection and sustenance. As they grow older, they are exposed to the patterns and expectations of their culture. Across generations, the family supplies a broad unit of support and enriches individual experience with a sense of continuity with the past and future. All these aspects of family can be assessed by how they contribute to the stability and prosperity of society. The same is true for other institutions.



Critics of functionalism argue that its emphasis on social stability is inherently conservative and

that it understates the roles of power and conflict in society. Critics also disagree with the explanation of inequality offered by functionalism—that it persists because social inequality creates a system for the fair and equitable distribution of societal resources. Functionalists would, for example, argue that it is fair and equitable that the higher social classes earn more money since they, so it is argued, are more important (functional) to society. Critics of functionalism argue that functionalism is too accepting of the status quo.

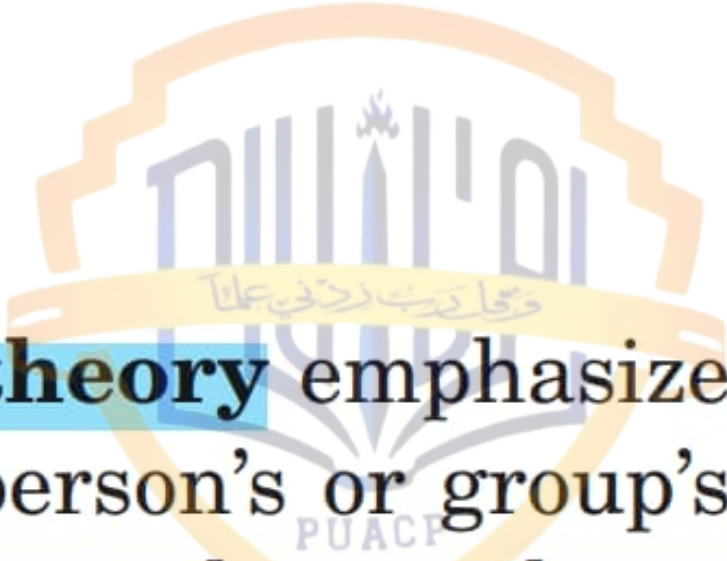
Conflict Theory

Conflict theory is rooted in the work of Marx and other social critics of the nineteenth century. **Conflict theory** *proposes that each individual or group struggles to attain the maximum benefit. This causes society to change constantly in response to social inequality and social conflict.*

For conflict theorists, social change pushed forward by social conflict is the normal state of affairs. Calm periods are merely temporary stops along the road. Conflict theorists believe social order results from those in power making sure that subordinate groups are loyal to the systems that are the dominant groups' sources of wealth, power, and prestige. The powerful will use coercion,

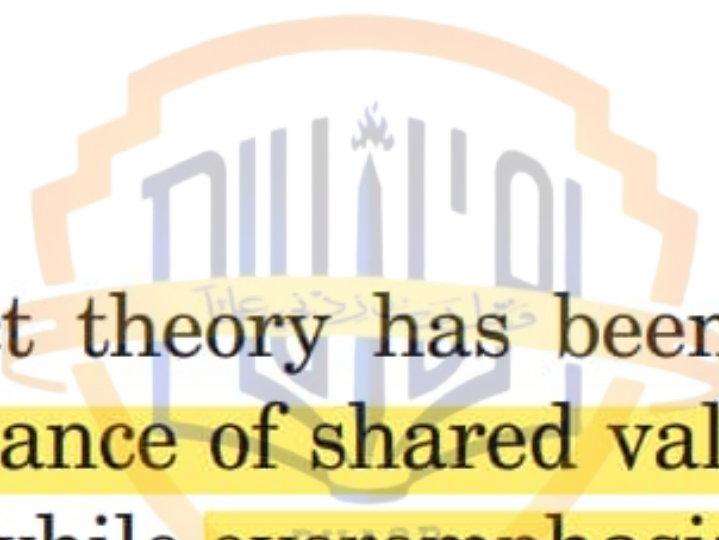
constraint, and even force to control those people who are not voluntarily loyal to the laws and rules those in control have made. When this order cannot be maintained and the subordinate groups rebel, change comes about.

Conflict theorists are concerned with the issue of who benefits from particular social arrangements and how those in power maintain their positions and continue to reap benefits from them. The ruling class is seen as a group that spreads certain values, beliefs, and social arrangements to enhance its power and wealth. The social order then reflects the outcome of a struggle among those with unequal power and resources.



Conflict theory emphasizes the role of coercion and power, a person's or group's ability to exercise influence and control over others, in producing social order. Whereas **functionalism** emphasizes cohesion within society, **conflict theory** emphasizes strife and friction.

According to conflict theory, inequality exists because those in control of a disproportionate share of society's resources actively defend their advantages. The masses are not bound to society by their shared values but by coercion at the hands of the powerful. In conflict theory, the emphasis is on social control, not consensus and conformity. Groups and individuals advance their own interests, struggling over control of societal resources. Those with the most resources exercise power over others; inequality and power struggles are the result. Conflict theory gives great attention to class, race, and gender in society because these are seen as the grounds of the most pertinent and enduring struggles in society.



Conflict theory has been criticized for neglecting the importance of shared values and public consensus in society while overemphasizing inequality. Like functionalist theory, conflict theory finds the origins of social behavior in the structure of society, but it differs from functionalism in emphasizing the importance of power.

Conflict perspectives are often criticized as concentrating too much on conflict and change and too little on what produces stability in society.

They also are criticized for being too ideologically based and using little in the way of research methods or objective statistical evidence. Conflict theorists counter that the complexities of modern social life cannot be reduced to statistical analysis and that doing so has caused sociologists to become detached and removed from the real causes of human problems.

The Interactionist Perspective

Functionalism and conflict theory can be thought of as opposite sides of the same coin. Although quite different from one another, they share certain similarities. Both approaches focus on major structural features of entire societies and attempt to give us an understanding of how societies survive and change. Social life, however,

The **interactionist perspective** focuses on how individuals make sense of—or interpret—the social world in which they participate. As such, this approach is primarily concerned with human behavior on a person-to-person level. Interactionists criticize functionalists and conflict theorists for implicitly assuming that social processes and social institutions somehow have a life of their own apart from the participants.

Interactionists remind us that the educational system, the family, the political system, and, indeed, all of society's institutions are ultimately created, maintained, and changed by people interacting with one another.

The interactionist perspective includes a number of loosely linked approaches. George Herbert Mead devised a *symbolic interactionist* approach that focuses on signs, gestures, shared rules, and written and spoken language. Harold Garfinkel used *ethnomethodology* to show how people create and share their understandings of social life. Erving Goffman took a *dramaturgical* approach in which he saw social life as a form of theater. (We will dis-

Symbolic Interactionism

As developed by George Herbert Mead (1863–1931), **symbolic interactionism** is *concerned with the meanings that people place on their own and one another's behavior.*

Human beings are unique in that most of what they do with one another has **meaning beyond the concrete** act

act. According to Mead, people do not act or react automatically but carefully consider and even rehearse what they are going to do. They take into account the other people involved and the situation in which they find themselves. The expectations and reactions of other people greatly affect each individual's actions. In addition, people give things meaning and act or react on the basis of these meanings. For example, when the flag of the United States is raised, people stand because they see the flag as representing their country.

for reflection, people give meaning to their behavior, and this is how they interpret the different behaviors, events, or things that are significant for sociological study.

Because of this, symbolic interaction, as its name implies, relies extensively on the symbolic meaning that people develop and rely upon in the process of social interaction. Symbolic interaction theory emphasizes face-to-face interaction and thus is a form of microsociology, whereas functionalism and conflict theory are more macrosociological.

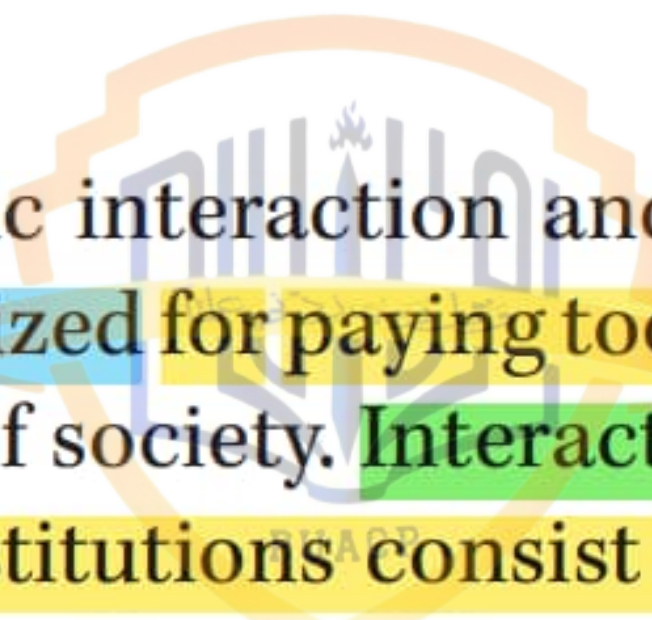
Derived from the work of the Chicago School, symbolic interaction theory analyzes society by addressing the subjective meanings that people impose on objects, events, and behaviors. Subjective meanings are given primacy because, according to symbolic interactionists and according to Thomas's dictum mentioned earlier, people behave based on what they *believe*, not just on what is objectively true. Thus, society is considered to be socially constructed through human interpretation

tani 1961). Symbolic interactionists see meaning as constantly modified through social interaction. People interpret one another's behavior, and it is these interpretations that form the social bond. These interpretations are called the "definition of the situation." For example, why would young people smoke cigarettes even though all objective medical evidence points to the danger of doing so? The answer is in the definition of the situation that people create. Studies find that teenagers are well informed about the risks of tobacco, but they also think that "smoking is cool," that they themselves will be safe from harm, and that smoking projects an image—a positive identity for boys as a "tough guy" and for girls as fun-loving, mature, and



dominant images of beauty. In other words, the symbolic meaning of smoking overrides the actual facts regarding smoking and risk (Stjerna et al. 2004).

Symbolic interaction interprets social order as constantly negotiated and created through the interpretations people give to their behavior. In observing society, symbolic interactionists see not simply facts but “social constructions,” the meanings attached to things, whether those are concrete symbols (like a certain way of dress or a tattoo) or nonverbal behaviors. To a symbolic interactionist, society is highly subjective—existing in the minds of people, even though its effects are very real.



Symbolic interaction and its various offshoots have been criticized for paying too little attention to the larger elements of society. Interactionists respond that societies and institutions consist of individuals who interact with one another and do not exist apart from these basic units. They believe that an understanding of the process of social interaction will lead to an understanding of the rest of society. Nevertheless, symbolic interactionism